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Claude Williams

Claude "Fiddler" Williams was born in Muskogee, Oklahoma in 1908. As a child he was surrounded by music and learned mandolin, guitar and violin. He received his first on-the-job training playing with the Black road shows that traveled across the southwest. Gigs with Andy Kirk's Twelve Clouds of Joy and bands in the hot jazz atmosphere of Kansas City honed his skills and Claude traveled with Count Basie's first swing band in 1936. His career has included work with rhythm & blues groups, collaborations with Jay McShann, and tours with his own groups here and abroad. Claude is the leading exponent of the Kansas City brand of swing and his violin playing can now be heard with the newly-formed Statesmen of Jazz. He makes his home in Kansas City and can be found at festivals and clubs across the country.

Claude was interviewed by Michael Woods on September 4, 1995, in Los Angeles. Monk Rowe also participated briefly in the interview.

MW: We are filming a interview for the Hamilton Jazz Archive with our guest today, Claude Williams, virtuoso violinist. Pleased to meet you.

CW: Same here, sir.

MW: Tell me, you've been playing for a long time, a lot of great music, with a lot of great performers. What first attracted you to the guitar and the violin?

CW: Well my brother-in-law was, knew quite a bit about strings and he started me out on, you know, we used to sit around the house and play old blues on guitar, and I'd watch him. And when he'd put the guitar down I'd pick it up and play blues. And he saw that I was interested, and he went and bought a mandolin and he would pick the melody on the mandolin and show me the changes on the guitar. So I actually played guitar. I got where I was pretty good but when he'd lay the mandolin down, I'd pick it up and play that. And going from the mandolin to, and he needed a bass in his string band, not knowing that a cello was too light, you know, it was also a lead instrument. But we got the cello and took the strings off and put bass strings on the cello. And I played bass, until Joe Venuti came through Muskogee. I heard him. He played at an outdoors pavilion. I was about half a block from him, you know, close as I could get you know? And I told my mother, "That's what I want to play." So the next day they changed the cello and brought me a violin home. And no problem, I played the violin. Because it's the same as the mandolin, you know, E-A-D-G you know? The mandolin got double strings, and you pick that. So I just picked up the fiddle and started playing. And they often asked me to, some of them, to play the first tune I remember playing on the violin. And the name of that tune was "You Got To See Your Mama Every Night Or You Can't See Your Mama At All."

MW: I wanted to ask you now, in some of those early days, the bands had string players is that right?

CW: Well not too early. You know violin was an important instrument for you know symphonies or bigger bands that got a violin section or something like that, but as far as just one violin, you hardly ever seen that in an orchestra.

MW: Now tell us how you got started playing the guitar for Basie.

CW: Well, like I say, guitar was my first instrument. I knew I played that before I did the violin. And it was quite a hit, the guitar was, for the type of violin that I was playing. I knew about changes and minors and diminishes and augmented and things like that I mean, whereas a whole lot of violin players didn't know nothing about that.

MW: And how did your guitar playing help you when you decided to play jazz on the violin?

CW: Well on account of me knowing about the changes, chords and things, you know? And when I took my first lesson I could play better than the teacher but I didn't know what I was playing so I still had to start over from, you know, C-D-E-F-G-A-D and down, and bowing all day and all of that. But it took me a long time to be able to play in tune, but being in my brother-in-law's string band, he was just carrying me around, you know, and I played pretty close. You know I remember when my brother went into the service in the war. I believe it was 1918. [sings] How you gonna' keep 'em down on the farm.

MW: Let me ask you. You say, you talk about the technique of playing the violin. Now unlike a guitar, a violin doesn't have any frets.

CW: No.

MW: You know, and —

CW: That's why it took me so long — me or anybody so long — to be able to play in tune, there ain't no frets. But this is why or how the guitar helped me play the violin. Like I say, by me knowing that C-E-G was a C chord, and C-E-G and B flat was the seventh, and the sixth, augmented, whatever.

MW: So that helped you to construct melodic lines along the confines of harmony. You actually understood the harmony rather than just playing individual notes.

CW: Uh huh. All along. You know you play the melody, you know all the melodies. Well now they have the changes up over the melody. But way back you have to figure out the changes and chords yourself. And like the pianist, a pianist could be, a finished piano player could play anything she sees. If you asked her to make you a C diminished chord she didn't know what you were talking about. They didn't teach that.

MW: That's another thing I wanted to ask you is, so you basically learned by, well you didn't study jazz in schools back then.

CW: No, no, they didn't teach nothing like it.

MW: So how did you learn?

CW: Well from—

MW: Records?

CW: No, well from other string band musicians coming through there and they're playing different tunes and as far as jazz, I mean jazz is just the way you attack some notes, you know, from like an eighth note to a sixteenth note or something. And you go from just playing a tune with knowing the chords and things, that helps you to add something to the tune. And you know, the easiest thing, like a blues, you know a blues is a twelve measure thing, and actually, you can actually take four chords and play the whole twelve measures you know. And then you can add fifteen or twenty more chords to it, you know, passing chords.

MW: Yeah. On one of your albums, you have a tune called "The Fiddler" where you mix jazz inflections with country influences. Tell us about that.

CW: Well "The Fiddler" is just actually a type of blues and with different changes and things you add to it, you know. Like [sings] every three or four notes, or every measure you play a different change. But it still starts from a blues idea. And as I tell people, Charlie Parker came up, you know, in Kansas City and I used to tell people that I taught Charlie Parker how to play and they'd look at me like I was crazy or something, you know. But Charlie, every time you'd see him he'd have his horn in a sack and his instruction book. And he could play anything in the instruction book, you know, he could read anything. But he didn't have nobody to show him how to go from a major to a minor — from a seventh to a diminished. And once he got that down, you couldn't stop him.

MW: So you helped him with his chord vocabulary?

CW: Um hum.

MW: Tell us some of the other musicians that you've played with.

CW: Oh, I really can't think of all the names. But I've been with so many different, uh, I was originally was with it turned out to be Andy Kirk's Twelve Clouds of Joy. It was first a fellow by the name of T. Holder. And T. Holder was from Muskogee also, that was my home. And he came in, and first he had a band in Tulsa by the name of Le Louvre. You ever know anything about a jitney dance? You ever heard of a jitney dance?

MW: Uh, no, tell me, tell me. I think this is something new for me.

CW: Well this was at Le Louvre, in Tulsa. And a jitney dance is a ten cents dance thing like a man would go and buy a roll of tickets and then go back and ask a lady to dance and if you want to dance. And there was a few fellows standing at the gate there and you'd go by and hand him these tickets. And when you get enough in this ring, he'd call out, "And now we'll have a foxtrot." So we had to be ready to play that foxtrot right then. And we'd play about maybe two choruses and he'd blow the whistle and that's the end of that. And he'd go by and ring you off and by the time you'd get them all off there'd be another

bunch going in. And every time you'd go into the ring you'd ask some lady to give a ticket. And why they were making so much money then, they gave away a brand new Ford every Friday night, if you held the right ticket, you know. You'd tear your ticket off and you'd keep the stub you know. And you'd put your stub, part of the stub tickets in the thing where they'd drop it. And they'd go in there and at the end of the week and feel around and 892 or something like that, that's you. You got a brand new Ford.

MW: I wanted to ask this, is you know, back then you talk about playing music for dances. How is the jazz different today? Do people still dance to it or has that changed the music?

CW: Well it really hasn't changed the music but just different styles of dancing with, you know, it need to be different tempos. And so that'll change the dancing. You know like back in jitterbug days, we're still playing the same music, but a little faster for jitterbugs you know. And then what made such a big difference in music over here you know, they didn't teach music in school for about ten years in some schools you know. Along about that time that's when the Beatles came over with rock & roll and they wasn't playing that much [scats]. So that's what they would listen to to dance. They really wasn't listening to no music, pretty music, or nothing to dance because they just listened to that beat. And that took over for at least ten years. But now they're teaching music in schools and the kids know what to listen for. When they hear a diminished chord or a minor chord or something, they appreciate that because they know what it is.

MW: Tell us, what is one of the most fun experiences you had as a musician, or one of the most awkward experiences?

CW: Well I had a lot of fun because I played with a lot of different musicians and all of them, take three or four musicians, all of them play the same tune down, they all have different ideas. And one would be if it's pretty to me it might not be pretty to you, but they play something else that's pretty, it sounds pretty to you. And, oh I always enjoyed a saxophone. And you know I used to like the way Ben Webster would play you know, and some stuff Coleman Hawkins would play. So, when I came to New York, I was up in New York in '76 at a club they call the Michael's Pub. And he said my violin sounded like an instrument, you know. Didn't sound like you hear a violin in a symphony. Because I was playing changes and chords you know, the same as a sax. And like a trumpet or like, oh I heard, when Louis Armstrong played, he made an introduction to that song — I can't think of that name, but he played a diminished chord for the introduction. [sings] Diminished. So I like those kinds of changes you know.

MW: Is there any one style of music that you favor above others?

CW: Well them is just jazz. I mean I was around, oh the hillbilly and — they don't call it hillbilly, what you call it?

MW: Country?

CW: Yeah, country, like they play in Nashville. I mean I was around there because you know I was in Tulsa around the Play Boy Flour there, what's that band that played there?

MW: Wills? Bob Wills?

CW: Yeah, Bob Wills. He was at Play Boy Flour for a long time. And he played, well I still called it hillbilly, but it's different. It's a different style of music. But I never, along that same time I was playing with my brother-in-law and we'd you know take a song and we'd play the melody out and then after playing the melody I mean I'd play some chords or changes or something like that. And that was all completely different from what Bob Wills was playing.

MW: And about the violin. You know you said in the early days there weren't that many people who played jazz on the violin. Tell us a little bit about this tour that you did with I think it was four other violinists what they play what they call "Folk Violin."

CW: Oh, yeah, well this tour, they had something like one, two, three, four – either four or five violins, and we all played a different style, you know. They had a cat playing Irish music, an Irish violin player, and we had this girl, oh she won all the fiddle concerts out east, I can't think of her name, and she was just about sixteen or seventeen but she could play and she was supposed to be a long-hair, Texas style player. And it's too bad I can't think of her name. I just saw her in New York two days ago. She's a big star playing that kind of stuff now. But like I said, four or five of us, and each one of us played a different style, and mine was jazz and then we had so many other different, I can't think of the different styles they had.

MW: Coming up being born in Oklahoma, which was the southwest at that time, can you describe for us how the southwest sound, like the Count Basie sound, was different from the sounds on the east coast or the west coast?

CW: Oh yeah, well it was different but I mean I don't know how I can explain to you the difference because in fact the Kansas City was different from any of the styles. Boys would come up from the south and Texas and Louisiana and all through there but they'd come through Kansas City and they changed their style somewhere. Because anytime you would tell somebody you're from Kansas City, they know that you are a good musician. If you've got the Kansas City stamp you've got it made. I can't tell you. It's different but I can't put my finger on it. I know at one time Bennie Moten left Kansas City and came to New York. And he made it real big with what they call a two four beat, instead of playing a number like [scats]. He played [scats]. And they fell in love with Bennie Moten's band.

MW: One other thing I would like to ask and that is you know the violin, for most people is considered a classical instrument. What things do you do with your fingers, with your phrasing, with your articulations to convert that instrument to a jazz sound?

CW: The chords, and the changes. I play [scats] a melody, and then a chord [sings]. You know that kind of stuff. That's what added to jazz other than just a straight melody. That was the first song I learned on the violin "You Got To See Your Mama Every Night" [sings]. So I'll be [scats]. And adding the jazz to it.

MW: Uh huh. Embellishing it. Tell us about the usage of blue notes. You've heard about that?

CW: What would that be now?

MW: Because you play them on an instrument where you have to use different fingering techniques.

CW: Well see you can bend, on the violin, you can bend them notes and slur those notes. That's what adds the blues to. You know slide it, or bend it. And it makes a different sound.

MW: Now if we, of course for our archive here we are hoping that a lot of young people will see some of these marvelous interviews and glean something. If you had a word that you could leave our young people with. If a young person was coming up wanting to study jazz violin, give him a word of your wisdom.

CW: Well in a few days I'll be down about 40 miles from Nashville. There's a place down there where there's something like 150 or 200 young violinists go twice a year to study violin. And it's by ear. I mean, not notes you know. So this will be my first year down there to teach them. And we heard another teacher down there. He'd start off and have a bunch of kids and he'd start off [hums] and have the kids hum that. They he'd [hums], and after they'd hum it a couple of times you say, now let's play that [hums]. They get to where they can play whatever they hum, and that's what they call by ear, you be playing by ear, you know? You don't see no notes or no kind of music. And they play, he'll start off humming the blues [humms] and have them hum that much. And then they say [hums]. And then they put that together for twelve measures and they're playing the blues you know. And that's by ear, strictly by ear.

MW: Tell us about working with Buddy Tate.

CW: Oh, well I knew Buddy from Texas or wherever he was from. And I ran into him because I was down there with a band, a territory band down there by name of Alphonso Trent. He was the first black band that played in the Adolphus Hotel in Dallas. And he was pretty well known all over Texas, Alphonso, so Buddy had worked with Alphonso around there in Texas. Something happened and the band finally broke up. And then T. Holder was down there with a different group. And he had picked up Buddy. And we played together in Texas. I just saw him a few months ago in New York, but he had a couple of accidents and he's been kind of sick, he hasn't been doing too much playing, but I went over and made him get his saxophone out and play a little. So when this jazz, the thing that we, the Jazz — Statesmen of Jazz, it's supposed to be all retired, not retired

but all musicians who are supposed to be from 65 up, you know. They call it "elder statesmen." So I had Buddy to come over, and went over in New York, and his picture is on one thing. We made him blow a few tunes and I made him play on one tune on the tape, but he's still weak you know, kind of sick. We had Buddy one night, it must have been about five or six years ago, I was with Jay McShann. We played a blues festival in Chicago. We had Buddy, he'd been sick then, but we brought him out on the stage and set him down and let him play. Man it was funny, but just the different tones the tenor players have. I mean Buddy has a different tone or something like, well I remember Herschel Evans got as close to Coleman Hawkins tone as I've ever heard. But Herschel and Lester and Coleman come through Kansas City and had one of them jam sessions. Lester would get on one side and Herschel would get on the other. And Herschel was trying to catch Coleman's tone. And Lester said, "Let him play, you don't need no tone." Boy at one time Lester could play more saxophone than anybody I've ever heard. And it was such a shame before he died, I could almost play as much saxophone, because [hums], stopped and he'd fill up behind them, like the blues singers you know, slow stuff, and he wasn't playing nothing. But he still had his style. And the different saxophones would try to play his style that he had when he passed.

MW: Had an individual voice.

CW: Hm?

MW: He had an individual voice on the instrument.

CW: Yeah. Just, Lester had, just like Coleman had different things. He couldn't get that big tone Coleman had.

MW: Do you think there are violinists that try to copy your style?

CW: Well it's a few violin players that, oh there's a lot of good violin players that I consider better than me now, but it's a different style. Like Grappelli plays a beautiful fiddle. When I was over in London last year or the year before last I was following him. Like Grappelli would play here this week and he'd move on and I'd play there. So they would say, "You know Grappelli plays pretty but I'd rather hear you." You know, my style was still different.

MW: I wanted to ask you a little bit more about the Kansas City scene. Can you tell us how it changed from the 30s going into the 40s and the 40s to the 50s?

CW: Well the only change in that is different attacks on notes and with the eighth notes, and then a whole note and then a couple of eighth notes [scats], you know and then [scats]; just different ways they was writing music. Everything changing. Like years back, Duke Ellington was so far advanced in his music, like the music he would write and play. For a while they were saying Duke Ellington was playing disco. They didn't know what they was listening to. They finally woke up with that. Duke was playing some flat fifths and

some raised ninths and things like that you know. Wasn't no disco, but once they figured out, find out what was happening, they tried to write it.

MW: Tell us about your Labor Day concert that you did in 1994.

CW: Well Labor Day, I mean I might play something, where, any particular place?

[Kansas City, the Nelson Arts Museum]

CW: Oh yeah I played there but didn't, other than, it wasn't a Labor Day thing. I mean I played there something like at least two or three times a year and I'm supposed to play there — one year I didn't play there because I was in New York pretty often. See my fellow that books me lives in New York and he's got an apartment. Any time I want to stay around New York, I mean, it won't cost me nothing, I mean my room and stuff like that because it's his place. But other than that I couldn't be around New York without working because hotel rooms are around a hundred dollars or better. You've got to be working or have something going to lay around New York.

MW: I want to just ask you a kind of final question here, is, you know you've seen a lot of music and played with a lot of great players. What do you see for the future of jazz? Where do you see it going? Or at least the future of jazz violin playing?

CW: Well let me see. It's, new things is happening every day. It's going to be some type of a change, but I mean I couldn't say right now what. Like I know anywhere from six to eight good violin players and they all play a different style. And even if they is going to read a sheet, they all read the same sheet, there would be a difference, because different ones would have different ways to attack the note. Because there is one, a correct way to attack, you know that they teach, and others is just another way of attacking because you can take lessons on a fiddle for twenty years, you know, before you're able to sit in a symphony. They called me to join this Black and Blue Revue show in New York. And they first called this fellow in Philadelphia. John Blake called me. But John didn't want to leave his family, so he said, "Why don't you get Claude Williams?" Well they had never heard of me. So John said, "Yeah well I have one of his albums." So they played a little taste of that and he said, "Yeah I can use him." So he called me and I know it was sort of frightening, you know for sure you're going to have to be able to read pretty good, you know. I told him I said, "Well I can read music but I ain't no symphony man, like where you have to sight read something. You put it down a time or two and I can play it." So he was listening to my album and he said, "Oh yeah, you can make it." So I didn't have no trouble, easy charts.

MW: And so that kind of gave you that pit experience.

CW: Well, yeah.

MR: [off camera] Could you ask Claude about—

MW: You go ahead.

MR: I'd like you to ask him, just so we have it on tape, some of the early stories about traveling down to Florida, and how that worked with the money they were making and them being picked up, and how the Count came to find you, and just a little bit about that?

CW: Yeah well we're jumping a long ways. Different times we'd have down in Florida — you know that was down south and quite segregated then, you know. And we played some dances for whites that the colored couldn't go to, and then we played some for colored that they wouldn't let the whites go to down south. They were all messed up like that. Like I say I heard Joe Venuti. I was standing almost about a block, at least a half a block from the pavilion, about as close as I could get to him, and he was in my home town in Muskogee then. And let's see that was down there. Oh, I knew Count before, you know Count came to Kansas City way before he ever had a chance to get him a group together we used to jam, we'd jam up and down the street there. And when the Count had been playing with Bennie Moten and Bennie Moten had got killed. He and the doctor was out partying all night and he went to have his tonsils taken out and never did wake up on the table. Well that doctor left Kansas City. I don't know what ever happened to him. And then so Bennie Moten's band broke up down to, Count was playing with Bennie then so Count just picked a few people that he wanted, you know, and started a small group there in a joint called Reno there in Kansas City. And he picked like him, the drummer, and bass, Walter Page they called "Big 'Un" he was in the Blue Devils — the Blue Devils had just broke up too about a year before then. So Count picked out a rhythm section and some, one or two saxophones or something like that, and was playing at this Reno Club there in Kansas City where they broadcast every night. It was such a strong station, I never will forget that W9XVY. It was a station you could hear just as good in New York as you could in Kansas City. So what happened, they broadcast every night from twelve to twelve thirty, or twelve thirty to one, something like that. And I hear Benny Goodman picked up the thing one night. And Benny told his brother-in-law which was John Hammond about the group, and John Hammond checked it and he went down to Kansas City and listened to it. In the meantime he was delighted with what he heard, and he laid some cash on Count for him to get him to enlarge his band. And I had been around Chicago playing. I played with Nat Cole and his brother had a band there. And King was, he was the best piano player in Chicago then, but he didn't know he could sing. He didn't even try to sing, he just played good piano. So a little thing happened and I didn't stay with them very long, so I was back in Chicago and Count heard that I was up there and he came up and picked me up and went back to Kansas City to enlarge his band. He enlarged it up to I think twelve or thirteen pieces. At that time Herschel was out there in California, Lester was there, Big 'Un was there, and oh the trumpet player, what they

called Hot Lips Page, he was there. See he had two different bands I think to pick from because the Blue Devils had broke up and there was some of them which — Hot Lips and Walter Page was the Blue Devils and Lester came up there with the Blue Devils, and so he really didn't have too much more after he got me to finish out the rhythm section. And Buck Clayton just happened to come through because Buck lived in Parsons, Kansas and he'd been living out here in L.A. So that's what happened with me joining Count.

MW: When did you do your first recordings?

CW: Well I really didn't get to record too many, I think one session with Count. And it was interesting, because after we got to New York, John Hammond you know he also told Count about me because he had some of his boys had been through Peoria, Illinois and I had been playing at a hotel there. And they checked on me playing fiddle and guitar, I played some of both. So I was playing guitar. And after we got to New York, John Hammond had promised some musicians there, you know, the first chance I get I'll put you with one of my bands, you know. So I got my notice, I got my notice in New York. I was the number one guitarist in New York in *Down Beat*. I told a friend of mine, "Man, I got my notice." He said, "Oh, man, ain't nobody in New York could fill your spot." I said, "Hell it ain't" and I got my notice in my pocket. So that was Freddie Green I mean he stayed with the Count for forty years or something after that. But Freddie couldn't — I was playing good guitar. After I left there, I said well I'm just going to try to play some fiddle. Because guitar was a hard instrument and it was a thing where after I played some guitar, with the chords, there was so much difference with the chords, and then when you play the fiddle you have to close back up because the positions is closer. It would take me a chorus before I could play in tune almost. So I just dropped the guitar and say I'm going to just play the fiddle. So that's the reason I'm just mostly playing fiddle.

MW: And you have quite a reputation as playing that fiddle, too.

CW: Man it's so different. There's a lot of good fiddle players, but we are all different.

MW: I would say you have a distinctive voice on the instrument. Well thank you very much. It's been a pleasure to interview you with a little help from our friends. And thank you and we look forward to catching one of your sets this weekend at the festival here.

CW: Yeah, I'll be on the scene about 6:00.

MW: Thank you.

CW: Thank you.